accountability of NGOs? Or is it that the NGOs and media are the modern priesthood that cannot be challenged? Who or what provides checks and balances for them? These are the kinds of questions that may indeed sound heretical in long-established democracies, where independent media and NGOs have emerged as a result of centuries-long process. But can that be equally said of media and NGOs in former Communist countries? These issues remain unexplored by the critics of the state of the rule of law in post-Communist countries, while Mr Orbán, with his handling of the Central European University in Budapest, certainly does not provide a helpful answer either.

However, notwithstanding their criticism of the rather superficial approach to the study of the state of the rule of law in Eastern Europe, Avbelj and Letnar Černič warn against politicians and, even more, academics justifying the truly troubling trends in Central Europe by describing the situation in these countries as having 'simply developed their own version of constitutionalism'. They find that unacceptable from the point of view of European values, that must indeed remain one and the same, valid for the whole Union. Instead, to rectify such a situation (both in Central and the rest of Europe), the authors call for measures at the EU level, such as deepening of the monetary union with the banking, fiscal, and social union. Another important area to make European countries' constitutional democracies more resilient has, according to the authors, to do with security, including border security. These steps should be complemented by structural reforms of the EU. However, when it comes to 'removing "dirty togetherness" from the institutional life', they admit that – in addition to reforms that they propose for executive and legislative branches of national governments, the constitutional framework, the judiciary, media and the private sector – 'how to proceed further is more difficult to answer. The most straightforward answers are to reform the mentality and bet on the education of a younger generation.'[200]

But educated minds, internalised values, meritocracy, transparency, integrity, professionalism of civil service etc. do not exist in a vacuum; they are attributes of holders of offices that these people have to internalise. The book stops short of explaining how to achieve that in practice, how to deal with informal old networks or how to roll back controversial legislative measures taken by governments – these would in many instances require a